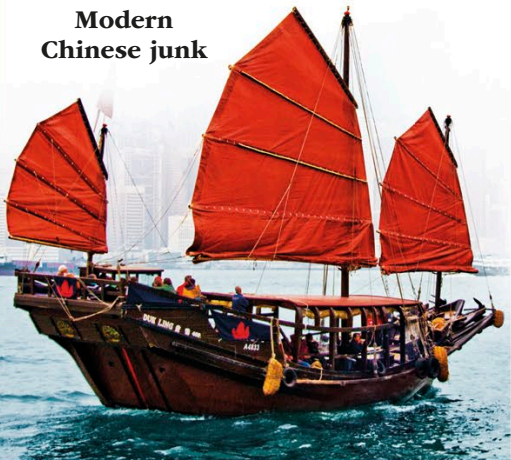


Chinese junk

- **What?** Chinese sailing ship
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** China, c. 2nd century CE

Early sailing boats, including junks, were designed in China and are used across Asia even today. They had square sails, held in place by pieces of wood called “battens,” which allowed each sail to be pulled open or closed easily and quickly.

Modern Chinese junk

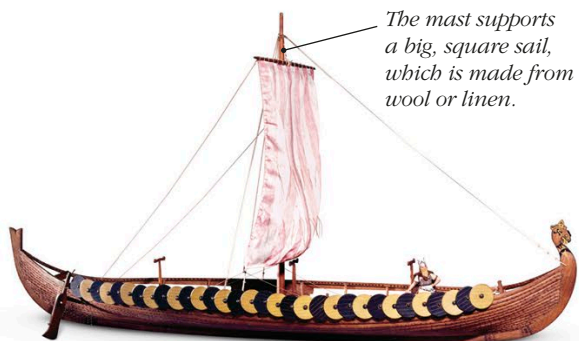


Longship

- **What?** Viking ship
- **Who?** Unknown
- **Where and when?** Norway, c. 9th century CE

The Norse people, also called the Vikings, of Scandinavia developed the longship. Vessels of this type were narrow and light enough to navigate up rivers but strong enough for the open sea. They could also navigate shallow waters. A longship had one large central sail and wooden oars for when there was little wind to power the boat.

The mast supports a big, square sail, which is made from wool or linen.



Model of a Viking longship

Sailing ships

The first wooden sailing ships were built in Egypt around 5,000 years ago, but across the world, other civilizations produced similar vessels. Until the 19th century, ships on sea voyages were mainly powered by wind captured in cloth sails. The vessels were used for trade, exploration, and war.

Sails were usually made of woven textiles.

